
FOR ASPIRING SALES LEADERS

From Rep to Sales Leader

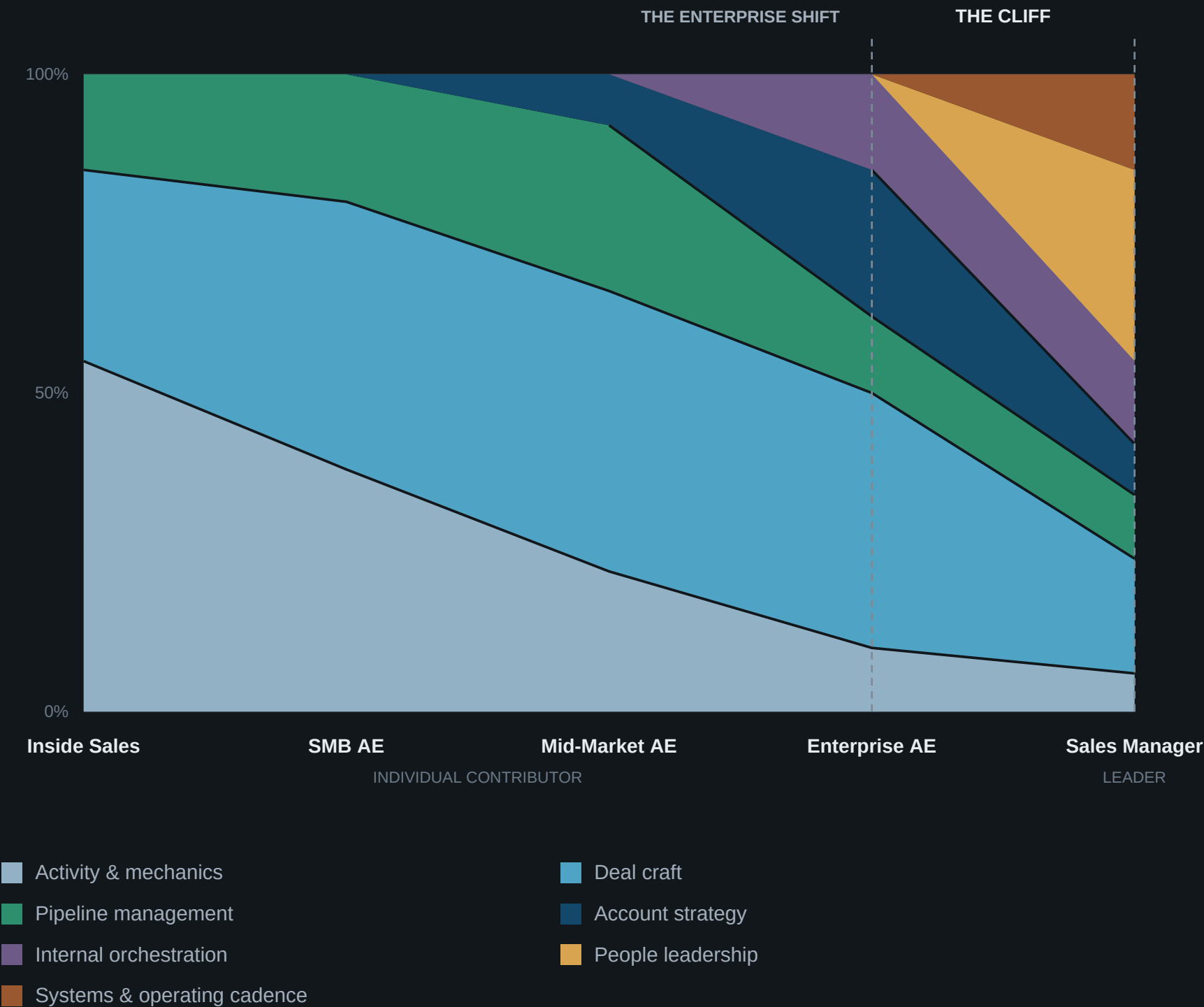
Three steps up the ladder are the same skills rebalancing. Then the job changes twice: once at Enterprise, and much harder at the manager seat.

What most career advice gets wrong

It tells you management is the next rung. The data says it is a different ladder. Here is what actually moves, and where.

The skill architecture

Each column sums to 100%. Width = share of the job.



26% → 12%

Enterprise is not a bigger Mid-Market job

Pipeline management halves. Account strategy triples, from 8% to 23%. The Mid-Market rep wins by working thirty deals well. The Enterprise rep wins by knowing six organizations better than the people inside them. Different skills that happen to share a job title family.

~40% flat

Deal craft holds its share and gets much harder

It sits near forty percent from SMB through Enterprise. That flatness is misleading. The enterprise version involves a buying committee, a procurement gate, and a cycle that outlives your memory of the first call. Same share of the job, different degree of difficulty.

15% → 13%

Internal orchestration is the only rehearsal you get

Running the SE. Pulling in legal and security. Managing an exec sponsor. It is the one skill on the entire IC ladder that means directing people who do not report to you, and the only band that survives the cliff nearly intact. If you want to manage, this is the part of the job to volunteer for.

45% new

Nearly half the manager job did not exist before

People leadership and operating cadence are zero percent of every role beneath the manager seat. There is no place on the IC ladder where you practice either one, and nobody has ever assessed you on them. Everything else on the chart grows gradually. These arrive all at once.

40% → 18%

The promotion is a subtraction

You do not add management to what you already do. You give up the work you are best at to make room for work you have never done. Reps fail as managers by taking the deal, and the team never learns to run one. That trade is the job.

Where to start

The toolbox for each transition, what you have to stop doing, and the artifact that proves you can lead before anyone gives you the title.

- **Inside Sales → SMB AE**
 - **SMB → Mid-Market**
 - **Mid-Market → Enterprise**
 - **Enterprise AE → Sales Manager**
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